



Mainland SE Asia

THE PENINSULA of Southeast Asia lies directly to the south of India and China, between the Pacific and Indian Oceans. It is made up of Myanmar (Burma), Thailand, Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos. Over thousands of years, the influence of people from nearby India, China, and Arabian countries has helped to give this region a diverse mix of cultures and religions. Much of the land here is mountainous, with half the region covered in forest. Most people live in coastal or lowland regions, where they can grow crops such as rice, raise cattle, and catch fish. In recent years, the electronics industry has also become an important part of southeast Asian economies, especially in Thailand.

ORPHANS IN CAMBODIA

A high number of Cambodian children live in orphanages, some because they have lost their parents, others due to poverty.



Cambodian orphanage

GROWING RICE
Rice is the most important crop in Southeast Asia. It grows well in wet lowland areas, such as the Mekong River delta in Vietnam, where the plants can be grown in paddy fields. Most rice is planted and harvested by women.



RURAL LIVING
Most people in Southeast Asia live in rural areas rather than cities, and farming is the most common occupation. The steep, mountainous regions are often unsuitable for growing crops or raising cattle, however, and many farming communities are based in the fertile river valleys and deltas. There are more than 200 villages on and around this lake (right) in Myanmar.

Paduang women, who are part of the Karen tribe, wear distinctive gold neck rings.



KAREN TRIBE
There are 600,000 tribespeople living in the northeastern hills of Thailand. The Karen are the largest hill tribe. They originated from Myanmar, but moved into Thailand to escape political unrest.

